

The "Great Masculine Renunciation" is a term coined by psychologist J.C. Flügel in *The Psychology of Clothes* (1930), describing the shift in men's fashion across the late eighteenth and nineteenth centuries in which, as he put it, man "abandoned his claim to be considered beautiful" and "henceforth aimed at only being useful" (Flügel, 1930). Yet the language of renunciation implies a loss, a claim given up under pressure. This essay argues instead that the plain suit was not a retreat from power but an instrument of it. The same century that stripped colour and ornament from men's dress also saw European colonial and industrial power reach its height, and the two developments were not coincidental. The suit's plainness signified rational, self-governing authority, a signification that did its most consequential work not only in European drawing rooms but across the colonies, where it marked the boundary between who governed and who was governed. Reading the renunciation this way requires holding two things together: the suit's domestic meaning as a marker of democratic, unornamented masculinity, and its imperial meaning as a uniform of civilisational superiority. Both readings describe the same object doing the same work, consolidating a new kind of power under the appearance of its absence.



Figure 1: Charles-André Van Loo, Unknown Artist Carrying the Order of Saint-Michel. c.1730–1740, Château de Versailles. © Art Resource NY / Christophe Fouin.



Figure 2: Joseph Karl Stieler, Portrait of Alexander von Humboldt, 1843, Charlottenburg Palace, Berlin. © Foundation Prussian Palaces and Gardens Foundation, Berlin-Brandenburg / Gerhard Murza.

Figures 1 and 2 make this argument visible rather than abstract. Van Loo's sitter, painted around 1740, wears a coat and waistcoat patterned with sprawling blue, gold, and rose florals, finished with wide lace cuffs and a powdered wig, and stands before a red curtain in a pose that draws the eye toward his own gesturing hand and toward the badge of the Order of Saint-Michel pinned to his chest. Every element of the image asks to be looked at: the fabric, the drapery, the theatrical stance. Beauty here is inseparable from status. The coat does not merely clothe the sitter; it performs his rank for the viewer.

Stieler's 1843 portrait of Alexander von Humboldt shows a man dressed in exactly the plain black coat and white cravat this essay has been describing, seated quietly beside a bookshelf and a large globe, his hands folded over a paper rather than gesturing outward. The contrast with Van Loo's sitter is not only sartorial. Humboldt was among the era's most celebrated explorers and naturalists, and the globe placed at his side signals a different kind of authority than the one claimed by embroidered silk: not the authority of visible wealth and inherited rank, but the authority of geographic knowledge and scientific reach,

the very intellectual apparatus that underwrote European exploration and colonial expansion. Read together, the two portraits do not show power disappearing between 1740 and 1843. They show it relocating, from the surface of the coat to the objects, the globe, the books, the papers, that surround the sitter and quietly assert his command of the wider world.

It was not until the nineteenth century that "masculine" became a term used to describe aesthetics in dress (Chapin, 2021). This new masculine ideal developed alongside what Breward (1999) calls a "vehement nonconformist Protestantism," which hardened the separation between masculine and feminine spheres. Chapin argues that in rejecting styles later coded as feminine, men asserted masculinity through opposition rather than through renunciation. The category of the feminine, in this account, did more than distinguish men from women. It also marked out nonwhite, non-Western, and non-heteronormative men as other (Chapin, 2021). Masculinity, femininity, and racial and colonial hierarchy were therefore built through the same gesture. This exclusion was not a zero-sum arrangement confined to any one group. Marginalised groups bore the costs of discrimination and diminished status, while men who embodied the new plain masculinity consolidated a form of social and cultural dominance that reached beyond gender into race and empire. The plain suit did not simply reject ornament. It rejected everyone and everything ornament had come to signify, whether the aristocrat, the woman, or the colonised man dressed in what European observers read as excess.

Part of the shift is explained by the practical demands of industrial labour. McCracken (1988) argues that durable, functional clothing suited the rigours of factory work and urban life better than ornamental dress, describing this new mode of consumption as one that encouraged simplicity of lifestyle and "the dignity of the common man" (McCracken, 1988). McCracken's phrase is worth pausing on. Dignity, in this framing, belonged to men who could claim rational restraint over their appearance, and that same claim of dignity through restraint would later do comparable work on a colonial stage, distinguishing the self-governing coloniser from those he judged incapable of the same restraint. Humboldt's

folded hands and unadorned coat in Figure 2 are this claim made visible: nothing in his posture or dress asks to be admired, and that refusal to perform is itself presented as a mark of seriousness. Breward similarly notes that plain dress allowed men from different social backgrounds to move through the new public spaces of the industrial city without their clothing announcing their status. But this account of practicality has a gap. The efficiency and affordability that defined the new masculine wardrobe were not neutral industrial achievements. Manchester's rise as the centre of British textile manufacturing depended on trade with West Africa built through the slave economy: before 1770, roughly a third of Lancashire's exports went into the West African slave trade, and by 1788 Manchester was exporting some £200,000 worth of goods a year into that trade. Once Manchester became known as "Cottonopolis," its mills ran on cotton grown by enslaved labour in the American South (Jacobin, 2025). The plain suit's practicality, then, was underwritten by a supply chain built on slavery. Framing the renunciation as a domestic story of taste and thrift treats as internal to Europe a transformation that was in fact sustained by extraction and forced labour elsewhere.

The nineteenth century's nationalist movements complicate the picture further. Breward (1999) links the rise of nationalism to renewed interest in indigenous costume and folk dress, as communities asserted cultural identity against political and cultural homogenisation. For the European man, engagement with the "indigenous attempts of resistance" that these revivals represented allowed him to define his own plain dress in direct opposition to indigeneity, reinforcing his status as a gentleman precisely by not looking like the people his empire governed (Breward, 1999). This opposition was not confined to Europe. The suit travelled with colonial administrators, missionaries, and merchants, worn as the uniform of rational, civilised authority in visual contrast to the dress of colonised populations. Bellanta and Cramer's study of "tropical whites," the all-white suits worn with pith helmets by European men in colonial port towns such as Darwin and Broome between 1900 and 1939, shows this dynamic in concrete detail. The all-white suit sustained inequalities of race, gender, and class in the colonial tropics, they argue, partly through its symbolic association with racial whiteness and imperial mastery, and

partly through its material demands: keeping a suit spotless in a tropical climate required constant laundering and starching, work typically carried out by colonised or racialised labour (Bellanta & Cramer, 2022). The suit's plainness was therefore not self-sustaining. It required an invisible labour force to keep it looking effortless, drawn from the very populations the suit was used to distinguish its wearer from. Breward himself situates the garment's meaning "much closer to the circumstances of its physical production than to its political symbolism" (Breward, 1999). This is a useful corrective to purely symbolic readings, but reviewers of his later work on the suit (Breward, 2016) have noted that Breward tends to step lightly around the deeper damage of colonialism and cultural dominance, even while discussing cultural diversity in dress (Fashion Studies Journal, 2016). Production and symbolism were not, in fact, separate. The suit's plainness carried political meaning precisely because of how and where it was produced and worn, making its material history and its imperial function two descriptions of the same garment.

Technological change reinforced this new masculine wardrobe's claim to democratic legitimacy. Kawamura (2004) describes a nineteenth-century "democratisation of fashion" driven by innovations such as the sewing machine, Bauwens' loom, and Heilman's embroidery machine, which lowered production costs and widened access to clothing across social classes. The sewing machine in particular reduced dependence on guild-trained tailors, replacing craft training with factory efficiency (Kawamura, 2004). Department stores extended this shift to the middle and lower bourgeoisie, though Kawamura notes that technological change alone does not explain the period's transformation in dress; it worked alongside shifting institutions and social structures. What this literature tends to leave out is where the raw material for that "democratic" wardrobe came from. Mass production made the suit widely available within Europe. It did so by drawing on a global system of extraction that made that availability possible in the first place.

A more sceptical reading might argue that the renunciation was fundamentally about class rather than empire, that plain dress served to level distinctions between aristocrat and

commoner within Europe, and that any imperial dimension was incidental to that domestic story. This objection is worth taking seriously, but it treats levelling and empire as competing explanations when they were in fact two effects of the same cause. Van Loo's sitter announces his rank through a badge, the Order of Saint-Michel worn openly across his chest in Figure 1, a mark of status that had to be granted by birth or royal favour. Humboldt claims authority in Figure 2 through no such badge. His standing rests instead on the globe and books beside him, on knowledge and discipline rather than inherited title, which is exactly the shift McCracken and Breward describe as levelling. What made the plain suit capable of levelling class distinctions within Europe was its claim to rational restraint rather than inherited privilege: a merchant in a well-made suit could stand alongside an aristocrat because his authority now rested on discipline and utility rather than birth. That same claim, that authority follows from rational self-control rather than inherited status, was precisely the justification European powers used for colonial rule. The commoner's right to stand beside the aristocrat and the coloniser's right to govern the colonised were argued through the same logic of earned rather than inherited authority. A reading that stops at class levelling captures half of what the suit was doing and leaves the other half, its work abroad, unexamined.

The Great Masculine Renunciation was not the loss its name implies. It was a reconfiguration of how power was signified and secured. Rejecting ornament allowed European men to distance themselves from aristocratic excess and to claim the moral authority of thrift, rationality, and self-control. That same rejection defined itself against femininity and against the colonised subject, and it was made materially possible by an industrial economy built on slave-grown cotton and colonial trade. Worn at home, the suit signified democratic restraint. Worn across empire, the same garment signified the right to govern. Van Loo's sitter and Stieler's Humboldt are separated by little more than a century, yet the distance between Figure 1 and Figure 2 is not a distance between ornament and its absence. It is the distance between one register of power and another, from a badge worn on the chest to a globe placed at the sitter's side. Reconsidered through this lens, the Great Masculine Renunciation was less a retreat from beauty than an extension of power

under a new and more durable disguise, one that the language of renunciation has helped keep hidden.

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